China, on the other hand, has a long history of imperial rule under one dominant ethnic group, the Han Chinese, which has, over the centuries, subdued and, in some instances, absorbed, other, minor groups of people. It is true that the last imperial dynasty in China, the Qing, was Manchu and that the country was somewhat multicultural in character during its reign (which lasted from 1644 to 1912) than it had been under previous emperors, possibly with the exceptions of the Liao, Jin, and Mongol dynasties, which were also non-Han. But while retaining some of their own ethnic identity, the Manchu elite also acquired all the trappings of traditional Chinese rulers. They spoke standard Chinese and the Manchu language almost died out in China in the nineteenth century. Even so, Dr Sun Yat-sen, one of the founders of the anti-Qing movement, wrote in 1904 that the goal of the struggle was 'to expel the Tatar [i.e., Manchu] barbarians'.[7] In 1912, the Qing Dynasty was overthrown and Dr Sun became the first president of the Republic of China. For decades after that, many families of Manchu descent tried hard to conceal their heritage and to conform to the Han Chinese customs and culture.[8]

Local dialects may differ in China, and several, among them Cantonese, Hakka, and Fujianese, are not mutually intelligible and differ from 'standard' Chinese, but the writing system, based on logograms and not on a phonetic alphabet, remains essentially the same all over the country. As for its political culture, China has long been dominated by authoritarian schools of thought, be it Confucianism or Communism in the past, or today's post-Communist totalitarian capitalism.

This is not to say that Chinese society would necessarily be incompatible with democratic values. Taiwan is a shining example of a country with a Chinese culture that has managed to shake off authoritarianism and become one of Asia's most vibrant democracies. But mainland China during the days of confrontation with India in the 1960s was a brutal dictatorship with a centuries-long history of authoritarian rule, and that has not changed even though a remarkable economic liberalization has taken place since the 'capitalist roader' Deng Xiaoping introduced his free-market reforms in the 1980s. There is a democratic opposition in China today, but it is still small and largely limited to dissident intellectuals.

When India became independent in 1947, it maintained many institutions that had been introduced during British rule such as an elected